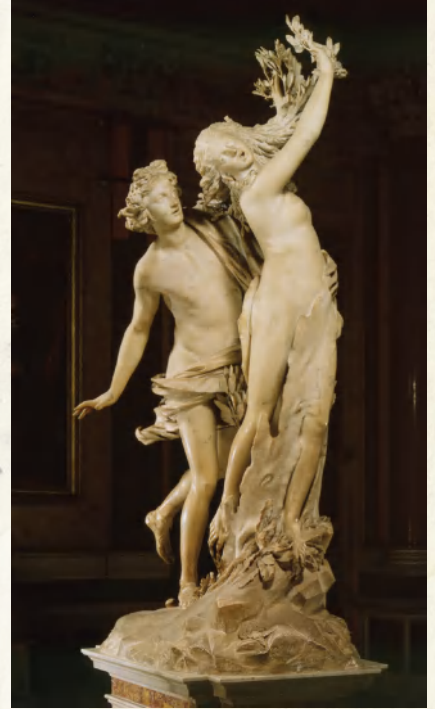


Apollo

Now the sun, the brilliant four-horsed chariot, shines down upon the earth and at the sky's fire the stars withdraw into holy night. The shining, untrodden crests of Parnassus receive for mortals the day's wheel. The smoke of dried myrrh wafts gently to Phoebus' roof. The Delphic woman sits on the sacred tripod, singing to the Greeks the cries which Apollo sounds.

—EURIPIDES, *Ion* 82–94



The Birth of Apollo

As has been told in the preceding chapter, Zeus mated with **Leto**, and she conceived the twin gods, Artemis and Apollo. The *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (3) concentrates in its first part (1–178: To Delian Apollo) on the story of how Delos became the site of Apollo's birth. The hymn begins with a scene of the gods in the home of Zeus (1–29):

I shall not forget far-shooting Apollo but remember him before whom the gods tremble when he comes to the home of Zeus. They all spring up from their seats as he approaches and draws his shining bow, and Leto alone remains beside Zeus, who delights in thunder. But then she unstrings his bow and closes his quiver and, taking them from his mighty shoulders, hangs them on a column of his father's house from a golden peg. She leads him to a chair and sits him down, and his father welcomes his dear son by giving him nectar in a gold cup. Then the other deities sit down in their places and the lady Leto rejoices because she has borne a son who is a mighty archer. Rejoice, O blessed Leto, since you have borne splendid children, lord Apollo and Artemis, who take delight in arrows; Artemis you bore in Ortygia and Apollo in rocky Delos as you leaned against the great and massive Cynthian hill, right next to the palm tree near the stream of the Inopus. (1–18)

10



Audio

How then shall I celebrate you in my song—you who are in all ways the worthy subject of many hymns? For everywhere, O Phoebus, music is sung in your honor, both on the mainland where heifers are bred and on the islands. All mountaintops give you pleasure and the lofty ridges of high hills, rivers flowing to the sea, beaches sloping to the water, and harbors of the deep. Shall I sing about how Leto gave you birth against Mt. Cynthus on the rocky island, on sea-girt Delos? On either side a dark wave was driven towards the land by shrill winds. From your beginning here, you rule over all mortals [including those to whom Leto came when she was in labor]. (19–29) 20

Leto had roamed far and wide in her search for a refuge where she might give birth to Apollo. The hymn continues with a long and impressive list of cities and islands to emphasize the extent of her wanderings; she visited all those who lived in these places (30–139):¹

Crete and the land of Athens, the islands of Aegina and Euboea famous for its ships, and Aegae, Eiresiae, and Peparethus by the sea, Thracian Athos, the tall peaks of Pelion, Thracian Samos, the shady hills of Ida, and Scyros, Phocaea, the sheer mountain of Autocane, well-built Imbros, hazy Lemnos, and holy Lesbos, seat of Macar, the son of Aeolus, and Chios, most shimmering of the islands that lie in the sea, craggy Mimas, the tall peaks of Corycus, gleaming Claros, the steep mountain of Aesagea, rainy Samos, the sheer heights of Mycale, Miletus and Cos, the city of Meropian mortals, and steep Cnidos, windy Carpathos, Naxos, Paros, and rocky Rheneae. (30–44)

DELOS ACCEPTS LETO

Leto approached these many places in labor with the far-shooting god in the hope that some land might want to make a home for her son. But they all trembled and were very much afraid; and not one of them, even the more rich, dared to receive the god Phoebus, until lady Leto came to Delos² and asked with winged words: “Delos, if you would like to be the home of my son, Phoebus Apollo, and to establish for him a rich temple—do not refuse, for no one else will come near you, as you will find out, and I do not think that you will be rich in cattle and sheep or bear harvests or grow plants in abundance—if you would then have a temple of Apollo, the far-shooter, all people will congregate here and bring hecatombs, and the aroma of rich sacrifices will rise up incessantly and your inhabitants will be nourished by the hands of foreigners.” (45–60) 20

Thus she spoke; Delos rejoiced and said to her in answer: “Leto, most renowned daughter of great Coeus, I should receive your son, the lord who shoots from afar, with joy, for the terrible truth is that I have a bad reputation among human beings, and in this way I should become greatly esteemed. But I fear this prediction (and I shall not keep it from you): they say that Apollo will be someone of uncontrollable power, who will mightily lord it over both immortal gods and mortal humans on the fruitful earth. And so I am dreadfully afraid in the depths of my heart and soul that when he first looks upon the light of the sun he will be contemptuous of me (since I am an island that is rocky and barren) and overturn me with his feet and push me down into the depths of the sea where the surge of the great waves will rise mightily above me. And he will come to another land that pleases him, where he will build his temple amidst groves of trees. But sea 30

monsters will find their dens in me, and black seals will make me their home without being disturbed, since I will be without human inhabitants. But if, O goddess, you would dare to swear to me a great oath that he will build here first of all a very beautiful temple to be an oracle for men; then after he has done this, let him proceed to extend his prestige and build his sanctuaries among all people; for to be sure his wide renown will be great.” (61–82)

Thus Delos spoke. And Leto swore the great oath of the gods: “Now let Gaea and wide Uranus above bear witness and the flowing waters of the Styx (this is the greatest and most dread oath that there is for the blessed gods), in truth a fragrant altar and sacred precinct of Apollo will be established here forever, and he will honor you above all.” (83–88)

LETO GIVES BIRTH TO APOLLO

When she had ended and sworn her oath, Delos rejoiced greatly in the birth of the lord who shoots from afar. But Leto for nine days and nine nights was racked by desperate pains in her labor. All the greatest of the goddesses were with her—Dione, Rhea, righteous Themis, and sea-moaning Amphitrite—and others too, except for white-armed Hera; for she sat at home in the house of Zeus the cloud-gatherer. Eileithyia, the goddess of pangs of childbirth, was the only one who had not heard of Leto’s distress, for she sat on the heights of Olympus beneath golden clouds through the wiles of white-armed Hera, who kept her there because she was jealous that Leto of the beautiful hair was about to bear a strong and noble son. (89–101)

But the goddesses on the well-inhabited island sent Iris away to fetch Eileithyia, promising her a great necklace strung with golden threads, over 13 feet long. They ordered her to call Eileithyia away from white-armed Hera so that Hera might not be able to dissuade the goddess of childbirth from going. When Iris, swift-footed as the wind, heard their instructions, she ran on her way and quickly traversed all the distance between. And when she came to sheer Olympus, home of the gods, immediately she called Eileithyia out of the house to the door and addressed her with winged words, telling her everything just as the goddesses who have their homes on Olympus had directed. (102–112)

EILEITHYIA ASSISTS LETO

Thus she moved Eileithyia to the depths of the heart in her breast, and like timid doves they proceeded on their journey. As soon as Eileithyia, goddess of the pangs of childbirth, came to Delos, the pains of labor took hold of Leto, and she was anxious to give birth. And she threw her arms about the palm tree and sank on her knees in the soft meadow, and the earth beneath her smiled. The baby sprang forth to the light, and all the goddesses gave a cry. There, O mighty Phoebus, the goddesses washed you with lovely water, holily and purely, and wrapped you in white swaddling clothes, splendid and new, fastened round about with a golden cord. And his mother did not nurse Apollo of the gold sword, but Themis from her immortal hands gave him nectar and delicious ambrosia. And Leto rejoiced because she had borne a strong son who carries a bow. (113–126)

But after you had tasted the divine food, O Phoebus, then no longer could golden cords hold you in your restlessness or bonds keep you confined, but they all were undone. And straightway Phoebus Apollo exclaimed to the immortal goddesses: “Let the lyre and curved bow be dear to my heart, and I shall prophesy

to human beings the unerring will of Zeus.” With these words Phoebus, the far-shooter with unshorn hair, strode on the ground that stretches far and wide; all the goddesses were amazed, and the whole of Delos blossomed, laden with gold like the top of a mountain with woodland flowers, as she beheld the son of Zeus and Leto, in her joy that the god had chosen her among all islands and mainland sites to be his home, and loved her most of all in his heart. (127–139) 80

The conclusion of this first part of the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* tells about the great festival to Apollo at Delos, the amazing chorus of maidens, the **Deliades**, who can sing in all dialects, and about the poet himself, the blind bard from the island of Chios (140–178):

And you yourself, O lord Apollo, far-shooter of the silver bow, come at times to the steep Cynthian hill of Delos, and on other occasions you wander among other islands and other peoples; indeed many are your temples and wooded groves, and every vantage point, highest peak of lofty mountains and river flowing to the sea, is dear to you. But, O Phoebus, your heart is delighted most of all with Delos, where the long-robed Ionians gather with their children and their revered wives. In commemoration of you they will take pleasure in boxing and dancing and song when they celebrate your festival. And anyone who might encounter the Ionians while they are thus assembled together would say that they were immortal and ageless, for he would perceive grace in them all and be delighted in his heart as he beheld the men and the beautifully robed women, the swift ships, and the abundant possessions. (140–155) 10

In addition to this, there would be the maidens who serve the far-shooting god, the Deliades, a great and wondrous sight, whose renown will never perish. They sing their hymn to Apollo first of all and then to Leto and Artemis, who delights in her arrows, and they remember the men and women of old and enchant the assembled throng with their songs. They know how to imitate the sounds and sing in the dialects of all human beings. So well does their beautiful song match the speech of each person that one would say he himself were singing. (156–164) 20

But come now Apollo with Artemis, and be propitious. Farewell, all you Delian maidens. Remember me hereafter when someone of earthborn mortals, a stranger who has suffered, comes here and asks: “Maidens, what man do you think is the sweetest of the singers who frequent this place and in whom do you delight most of all?” Then all of you answer that I am the one: “A blind man who lives in rocky Chios; all his songs are the best forevermore.”³ (165–173)

I will bring your renown wherever I roam over the earth to the well-inhabited cities of humans; and they will believe since it is true. Yet I shall never cease to hymn the praises of Apollo, god of the silver bow, whom Leto of the beautiful hair bore. (174–178) 30

Apollo and Delos

It is most evident from the *Homeric Hymn* that the island of Delos was sacred to Apollo and the location of one of his most important sanctuaries, as the impressive remains today confirm. The following story was told about Anius, the son of Apollo.

Delos was the home of Anius, who was both his father's priest and king of the island at the time of the Trojan War. He had three daughters, Elaïs (Olive Girl), Spermo (Seed Girl), and Oeno (Wine Girl), who received from Dionysus the power of producing, respectively, oil, grain, and wine. Agamemnon attempted to compel them to go to Troy with the Greeks to supply the army with these provisions. As they resisted and tried to escape, Dionysus turned them into white doves; ever after, doves were sacrosanct at Delos.

Apollo and Delphi

Some believe that the first part of the lengthy *Hymn to Apollo* was originally a separate composition, a hymn to Delian Apollo. The second part of the hymn, which is translated in the Additional Reading at the end of this chapter, would have been recited as a song to **Pythian Apollo**, the god of Delphi.⁴ Filled with a wealth of mythological information, it tells how Apollo descended from Mt. Olympus and made his way through northern and central Greece, finally discovering the proper spot for the foundation of his oracle among humankind at Crisa under snow-capped **Parnassus**. Apollo laid out his temple and then slew a she-dragon by the fair-flowing stream nearby. The name of the site was henceforth called Pytho (and Apollo, the Pythian) because the rays of the sun made the monster rot. (The Greek verb *pytho* means "I rot.")⁵

A cogent historical reconstruction of the conflicting evidence⁶ suggests that originally the site was occupied by an oracle of the great mother-goddess of the Minoan-Mycenaean period, sometimes known as Ge-Themis. The slaying of the dragon (the traditional manifestation of a deity of earth), therefore, represents the subsequent conquest by Hellenic or Hellenized Apollo. For murdering the dragon, Zeus sent Apollo into exile in Thessaly for nine years (his punishment presumably mirrors the religious dictates of ancient society).⁷

The **omphalos**, an archaic stone shaped like an egg, which was kept in the temple during the classical period, seems to confirm an early habitation of the site.⁸ Legend has it that this omphalos (the word means "navel") signified that Delphi actually occupied the physical center of the earth (certainly it was in many ways the spiritual center of the ancient world). Zeus was said to have released two eagles who flew from opposite ends of the earth and met exactly at the site of Apollo's sanctuary—a spot marked out for all to see by the stone omphalos with two birds perched on either side.

The hymn to Pythian Apollo concludes with a curious and interesting story. After he had established his sanctuary at Crisa, Apollo was concerned about recruiting attendants to his service. He noticed a ship passing, manned by Cretans from Cnossus, on its way to sandy Pylos. Phoebus Apollo transformed himself into a dolphin and immediately sprang aboard. At first, the men tried to throw the monster into the sea, but such was the havoc it created that they were awed to fearful submission. Speeded on by a divine wind, the ship would not obey the efforts of the crew to bring it to land. Finally, after a lengthy course, Apollo led them to Crisa, where he leaped ashore and revealed himself as a god amid a blaze of fiery brightness and splendor. He addressed the Cretan men, ordering them to perform sacrifices and pray to him as **Apollo Delphinus**. Then he led them to his sanctuary, accompanying them on the lyre as they chanted a paean in his honor. The hymn ends with the god's instruction to the Cretan band, who

are placed in his charge, and his prediction of the prestige and wealth that is to come to his sanctuary.

The story links the early cult of Apollo with Crete, explains the epithet Delphinus in terms of the Greek word for dolphin, and provides an etymology for Delphi as the name of the sanctuary. As god of sailors and of colonization (his oracle was consulted to give religious sanction for the establishment of colonies), Apollo was worshiped under the title Delphinus. The hymn as a whole confirms the universality of the worship of Apollo and the importance of his outstanding cult centers, certainly at Delos but above all at Delphi.

The sanctuary of Apollo at Delphi is representative of the nature and character of other Panhellenic sites elsewhere.⁹ The sacred area was built on the lower slopes of Mt. Parnassus, about 2,000 feet above the Corinthian Gulf. It is an awe-inspiring spot to this day. For anyone walking along the Sacred Way up to the great temple of the god, it is not difficult to sense the feelings of reverence and exaltation that filled the heart and soul of the ancient believer. The excavations have laid bare the foundations of the many and varied types of monuments along the winding path that were set up by individuals and city-states in honor and gratitude. Small temples (called treasuries) were a particularly imposing type of dedication, erected to house expensive and precious offerings. Among the major buildings of the sanctuary were a stadium, a theater, and of course the great temple of Apollo himself.

The **Pythian Games**, which were celebrated every four years, included (after 582 B.C.) both physical and intellectual competitions. Footraces, chariot races, and musical, literary, and dramatic presentations were among the events that combined to make the festival second only to that of Zeus at Olympia. The sanctuary and the celebrations reflect much that is characteristic of Greek life and thought. The numerous triumphant dedications of victory in war mirror the narrow particularism and vehement rivalry among individual city-states, while the fact of the festivals themselves, to which *all* Greeks might come to honor gods common to their race, reveals the strivings toward a wider and more humane vision. Certainly, the sense of competition in both athletics and the arts was vital to the Greek spirit. The importance of both the physical and the aesthetic also suggests a fundamental duality made one and whole in the prowess and intellectuality of the god Apollo himself. The *Odes* of **Pindar**, written to celebrate the glorious victors in the athletic competitions, are among the most sublime lyrical outpourings of the human spirit. Physical excellence intensified a sense of physical beauty that inspired Greek artists to capture in sculpture and in painting the realism and idealism of the human form. The development of the Doric, Ionic, and Corinthian orders and the construction of magnificent architectural buildings were also inspired by religious as well as civic devotion. The spiritual and human impetus to great feats of body and mind is among the most wondrous achievements of the Greek religious experience.

The Oracle and the Pythia at Delphi

The Panhellenic sanctuary of Delphi was above all an oracle.¹⁰ People from all over the Greek world (and even beyond) came to Apollo with questions of every sort, both personal and political. Herodotus' story of Solon and Croesus, translated in Chapter 6, testifies to the prestige of the god, already well established in

the sixth century, and provides primary evidence for the nature and form of his responses as well.

The exact oracular procedures followed cannot be determined precisely because our sources are inadequate. The Pythia (prophetess of Apollo) uttered the responses of the god. Her seat of prophecy was the tripod, a bowl supported by three metal legs. A tripod was a utensil of everyday life; a fire could be lit beneath or inside the bowl, and it could be used for many obvious practical purposes. The tripod at Delphi was both a symbol and a source of divine prophetic power. Ancient pottery depicts Apollo himself seated on the bowl; his Pythian priestess, who does likewise, becomes his mouthpiece. In a frenzy of inspiration, she utters her incoherent ravings. A priest or prophet nearby will transcribe them into intelligible prose or verse (usually dactylic hexameters) to be communicated to the inquirer (see box on p. 254).

The Pythia prophesied in the inner sanctuary of the temple, the adyton (in which there was placed a stone omphalos, the navel marking the center of the earth), where vaporious gases could have emerged from a cleft below to enhance her inspiration. The exact location of the adyton cannot be located in the ruins of the excavated temple. The Pythia herself underwent certain initial ceremonies to ensure purification—among them a ritual drinking of the sacred water from the famous Castalian spring.

The inquirer who came to the temple with his question for the god had to go through certain prescribed ceremonies that were in the nature of a fee.¹¹ First he had to offer an expensive sacred cake on the altar outside the temple; and once he had entered, he was required to sacrifice a sheep or goat, a portion of which went to the Delphians. After these preliminaries, he could enter the adyton, the holy of holies, the innermost shrine of the temple, where he took his seat to wait for his turn to make his enquiry.¹²

In early times, according to tradition, the Pythia was a young virgin. On one occasion, an inquirer fell in love with one and seduced her. From then on, only mature women (probably over fifty years old, who dressed in the costume of a maiden) could become priestesses; whatever the nature of their previous lives (they could have been married), purity was required once they had been appointed to serve the god for life. At times, one from among at least three women could be called upon to prophesy, and there were probably more in reserve.¹³ During the winter, when Apollo left for the land of the Hyperboreans, as was believed, the oracle was closed; thus, the Pythia prophesied for only nine months of the year.

Inevitably, one must wonder about the religious sincerity of the priests and priestesses at Delphi. Was it all a fraud? There is no good reason to think so. Many people have believed in the possibility of god communicating with mortals in marvelous ways. And belief in a medium, a person with special mantic gifts, is by no means unique to the Greeks. The Pythia presumably was chosen because of her special nature and religious character—she was susceptible to supernatural callings. It is true that the oracle was often on the side of political expediency and that the ambiguity of the responses was notorious. Apollo's obscure epithet, Loxias, was thought to bear testimony to the difficult and devious nature of his replies. But only a glance at the life and career of Socrates shows the sincere and inner religious meaning that an intellectually devout person is able to wrest from the material trappings of established institutions



Aegeus before Themis. Red-figure kylix, by the Codrus painter, ca. 440 B.C.; 12.8 in. in diameter. Aegeus, crowned with laurel, is seen consulting Themis about why he cannot have children (see p. 626). In the opening lines of Aeschylus' *Eumenides*, the priestess gives a genealogy in which Ge is the first Pythia, followed by her daughter Themis. She holds a phiale or libation vessel in her left hand, into which she seems to be gazing intently; it is unclear whether it is an instrument of prophecy. She holds in her right hand a laurel branch, sacred to Apollo, and the tripod she is sitting on makes clear that the scene is at Delphi. The Doric column indicates that we are within the temple of Apollo. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

The Controversy about the Pythia and Her Prophecies

Ancient sources attest that after hallucinogenic effects caused by gases were observed in the behavior of goats and shepherds, a tripod was set up over the chasm for a priestess to breathe the vapors and, under their intoxicating influence, utter her oracles.¹⁴ Archaeological and geological investigations at the site of the temple of Apollo have revealed that the Pythia actually could have inhaled narcotic fumes (from such gases as methane, ethane, and especially ethylene), created in the highly volcanic region of Delphi. Two faults were identified that meet directly under the temple.¹⁵ As a result, much debate has been aroused about the nature and procedure of the Pythia in particular and prophets and prophecy in general, with the challenging of traditional theories.

A persistent consensus may be emerging (especially as a result of a reexamination of procedure described in Herodotus) in support of the argument that the Pythia herself gave her oracles in comprehensible verses, in dactylic hexameter, directly to the inquirer, who could then write them down and take them home, with absolutely no priestly intervention. If intoxicating vapors or any other hallucinatory drugs were used to enhance communication with Apollo, the priestess was not reduced to incoherent ravings that needed to be interpreted by a priest.

It is impossible to debate the problems here, and so we can pose only a few of the many troubling questions. Final answers must, however, still remain elusive because of the inadequate and conflicting evidence, much of which comes from later sources, especially Plutarch, a Delphic priest to be sure, but in the second century A.D., when practices at Delphi must have changed significantly.

It is perfectly credible that a priestess could improvise dactylic verses on the spot, but would she not have needed, to some degree, special qualifications or training? How deep could her communication with Apollo go, and how could a Pythia control possession by the god? Could an enquirer easily copy down her recitation of verses for retention, without some help? Many oracles quoted by Herodotus are by no means simple. How did these oracles survive as many most certainly did? Are the some 600 that have come down to us today merely frauds? The male temple hierarchy at Delphi was large. How was the priesthood (both male and female) organized? Is it conceivable that the Pythia herself would be solely and primarily responsible for creating pronouncements about important political affairs, including issues of war and peace, with great consequences not only for Delphi but the entire Greek world and beyond? There are examples of Pythias acting like crazed mediums, raving like the Cumaean Sibyl, as described by Vergil, presumably accurately, even allowing for poetic license. Was oracular procedure generally the same throughout the Greek and Roman world and similar for both female and male prophets (those originally at Dodona, for example)?

Jelle Z. De Boer, a principal researcher in the investigation at Delphi, concludes that ethylene did “not much” for the Pythias. It was only “one of many stimuli to a deeply religious state of mind.” These were inspired women, “a sisterhood of mystics,” and not druggies “in a narcotic haze.” The team’s discoveries “did little to explain or diminish the Oracle’s possibilities, even otherworldly ones” and “said nothing about a range of oracular feats that were indisputably real.” Michael Attyah Flower draws a modern parallel with the Chief State Oracle of Tibet, located at the monastery of Nechung in Northern India: “The Nechung oracle, a male priest, is called the Kuden (which means “receiving body”) and acts as the mouthpiece of the counseling spirit Dorje Drakden (the Renowned Immutable One).” His inspired prophecies are intelligible and believed today.¹⁶

in any society. According to Plato's *Apology*, Socrates' friend Chaerephon went to Delphi to ask who was the wisest of men. The answer was "Socrates." When the philosopher learned this, he could not rest until he had determined the meaning of the response and proved the god right. If we are to take the *Apology* at all literally and historically (and why not?), this message from Apollo provided a turning point for Socrates in his missionary-like zeal to make men and women think of eternal moral and ethical values because of a belief in their immortal souls.

The Cumaean Sibyl

The Pythia is the specific title given to the priestess of Apollo at Delphi. A more generic term for prophetess was Sibyl, and many Sibyls were found at various places in various periods in the ancient world. Originally, the title was probably the proper name (Sibylla) of an early prophetess. At any rate, the Sibyls at Cumae were among the most famous seers of antiquity.¹⁷ The description of the Cumaean Sibyl acting like a medium as she prophesies to Aeneas helps us understand the nature of the communication of a prophetess with her god, even though we must allow for poetic imagination.¹⁸ The innermost shrine of the temple is a cavern from which the responses issue (Vergil, *Aeneid* 6. 42–51):

The vast end of the temple, built of Euboean stone, is cut out into a cavern; here are a hundred perforations in the rock, a hundred mouths from which the many utterances rush, the answers of the Sibyl. They had come to the threshold, when the virgin cried: "Now is the time to demand the oracles, the god, behold, the god!" She spoke these words in front of the doors, and her countenance and color changed; her hair shook free, her bosom heaved, and her heart swelled in wild fury; she seemed of greater stature, and her cries were not mortal as she was inspired by the breath of the god drawing nearer.

Later follows the metaphor of a wild horse trying to throw its rider (77–82, 98–101):

Not yet willing to endure Apollo, the prophetess raged within the cavern in her frenzy, trying to shake the mighty god from her breast; all the more he wore out her ravings, mastering her wild heart and fashioning her to his will by constraint. Now the hundred mouths of the cavern opened wide of their own accord and bore the responses of the prophetess to the breezes. . . . The Cumaean Sibyl chants her terrifying riddles and, from the innermost shrine of the cavern, truth resounded, enveloped in obscurity, as Apollo applied the reins to her raving and twisted the goad in her breast.

Earlier in the *Aeneid* (3. 445), the seer Helenus warned Aeneas that the Sibyl wrote her prophecies on leaves that were carefully arranged. But when the doors of the cavern were opened, these leaves were scattered by the wind so that those who had come for advice left without help and hated the dwelling of the Sibyl. Thus, Aeneas asks (6. 74–76) that the Sibyl utter the prophecies herself and not entrust them to the leaves. All this may be an oblique reference to some characteristic of the **Sibylline books** (collections of prophecies of the Sibyls often consulted by the Romans) and the way in which they were interpreted.¹⁹

Ovid has the Sibyl tell Aeneas the story of her fate (*Metamorphoses* 14. 132–153):

Eternal life without end would have been given me if I had yielded my virginity to Phoebus Apollo who loved me. He hoped that I would and desired to bribe me with gifts, so he said: “Virgin maid of Cumae, choose what you desire; you will attain whatever it is.” I picked up a heap of sand, showed it to him and asked for the vain wish that I might have as many birthdays as the individual grains in my hand. I forgot to ask for continuous youth along with the years. He would have given me both, long life and eternal youth, if I had succumbed to his love. But I despised Phoebus’ gift, and I remain unmarried. And now the happier time of youth is gone, and sick old age has come with its feeble steps; and I must endure it for a long time. (132–144)

10

For now, as you see, I have lived through seven generations; there remain for me to witness three hundred harvests, three hundred vintages in order to equal in years the number of grains of sand.²⁰ The time will come when length of days will have reduced me from my former stature and make me small, and my limbs consumed by age will be diminished to the tiniest weight. And I shall not seem like one who was pleasing to a god and loved by him. Perhaps even Phoebus himself either will not recognize me or will deny that he once desired me; I shall be changed to such an extent that I shall be visible to no one, but I shall be recognized by my voice; the Fates will leave me my voice. (144–153)

In another version, the Sibyl became a tiny thing suspended in a bottle. Boys asked: “Sibyl, what do you want?” Her answer was: “I want to die.”²¹

Other Loves of Apollo

Apollo, just as many a god or goddess, has sexual or emotional appetites that he desires to be fulfilled. It is worth noting that Apollo, unlike his father Zeus, is sometimes quite unsuccessful.

Apollo and Cassandra

Priam’s daughter Cassandra, a pathetic figure in the Trojan saga, was another of Apollo’s loves and another prophetess. When she agreed to give herself to Apollo, as a reward the god bestowed upon her the power of prophecy. But Cassandra then changed her mind and rejected his advances. Apollo asked for one kiss and spat into her mouth. Although he did not revoke his gift, Cassandra was thereafter doomed to prophesy in vain, for no one would believe her.

Apollo and Marpessa

Apollo also attempted to win Marpessa, daughter of Evenus, a son of Ares. She was also wooed by Idas, one of the Argonauts, who carried her off in his chariot against the will of her father. Evenus unsuccessfully pursued the pair, and then in his anger and heartbreak committed suicide. Subsequently Apollo, who had also been a suitor for Marpessa’s hand, stole her away from Idas in similar fashion. Ultimately the two rivals met face to face in conflict over the girl. At this point, Zeus intervened and ordered Marpessa to choose between her lovers. She

chose Idas because he was a mortal, for she was afraid that the undying and eternally handsome god Apollo would abandon her when she grew old.

Apollo and Cyrene

Nearly all of Apollo's numerous affairs are tragic; he is perhaps the most touchingly human and the most terrifyingly sublime of all the Greek gods. A notable exception is his success with Cyrene, an athletic nymph, with whom he fell in love as he watched her wrestling with a lion. He whisked her away to Libya in his golden chariot, to the very site of the city that would be given her name, and she bore him a son, Aristaeus.²²

Apollo and Daphne

The story of Apollo's love for Daphne explains why the laurel (the Greek word *daphne* means "laurel") was sacred to him. Ovid's version is the best known (*Metamorphoses* 1. 452–567):

Daphne, daughter of Peneus, was the first object of Apollo's love. It was not blind fate that brought this about, but Cupid's cruel anger. Apollo, flushed with pride at his victory over Python, had seen Cupid drawing his bow and taunted him: "What business of yours are brave men's arms, young fellow? The bow suits *my* shoulder; I can take unerring aim at wild animals or at my enemies. I it was who laid low proud Python, with uncounted arrows, though he stretched over wide acres of ground. You should be content with kindling the fires of love in some mortal with your torch; do not try to share my glory!" (452–462)

To him Cupid replied: "Although your arrows pierce every target, Apollo, mine will pierce you. Just as all animals yield to you, so your glory is inferior to mine." And as he spoke, he quickly flew to the peak of shady Parnassus and from his quiver drew two arrows. Different were their functions, for the one, whose point was dull and leaden, repelled love; the other—golden, bright, and sharp—aroused it. Cupid shot the leaden arrow at Peneus' daughter, while he pierced Apollo's inmost heart with the golden one. (463–473)

Straightway Apollo fell in love, and Daphne ran even from the name of "lover." As a companion of Diana, her joy was in the depths of the forests and the spoils of the chase; a headband kept her flowing hair in place. Many suitors courted her, while she cared not for love or marriage; a virgin, she roamed the pathless woods. Her father often said, "My daughter, you owe me a son-in-law and grandchildren"; she, hating the marriage torch as if it were a disgrace, blushed and embraced her father saying, "Allow me, dearest father, always to be a virgin. Jupiter granted this to Diana." Peneus granted her prayer; but Daphne's beauty allowed her not to be as she desired and her loveliness ran counter to her wish. (474–489)

Apollo loved her; he saw her and desired to marry her. He hoped to achieve his desire, misled by his own oracle. Even as the stubble burns after the harvest, or a hedge catches fire from a careless traveler's embers, so the god burned with all-consuming fire and fueled his love with fruitless hope. He sees her hair lying unadorned upon her neck and says, "What if it were adorned?" He sees her flashing eyes like stars; he sees her lips—and merely to see is not enough.

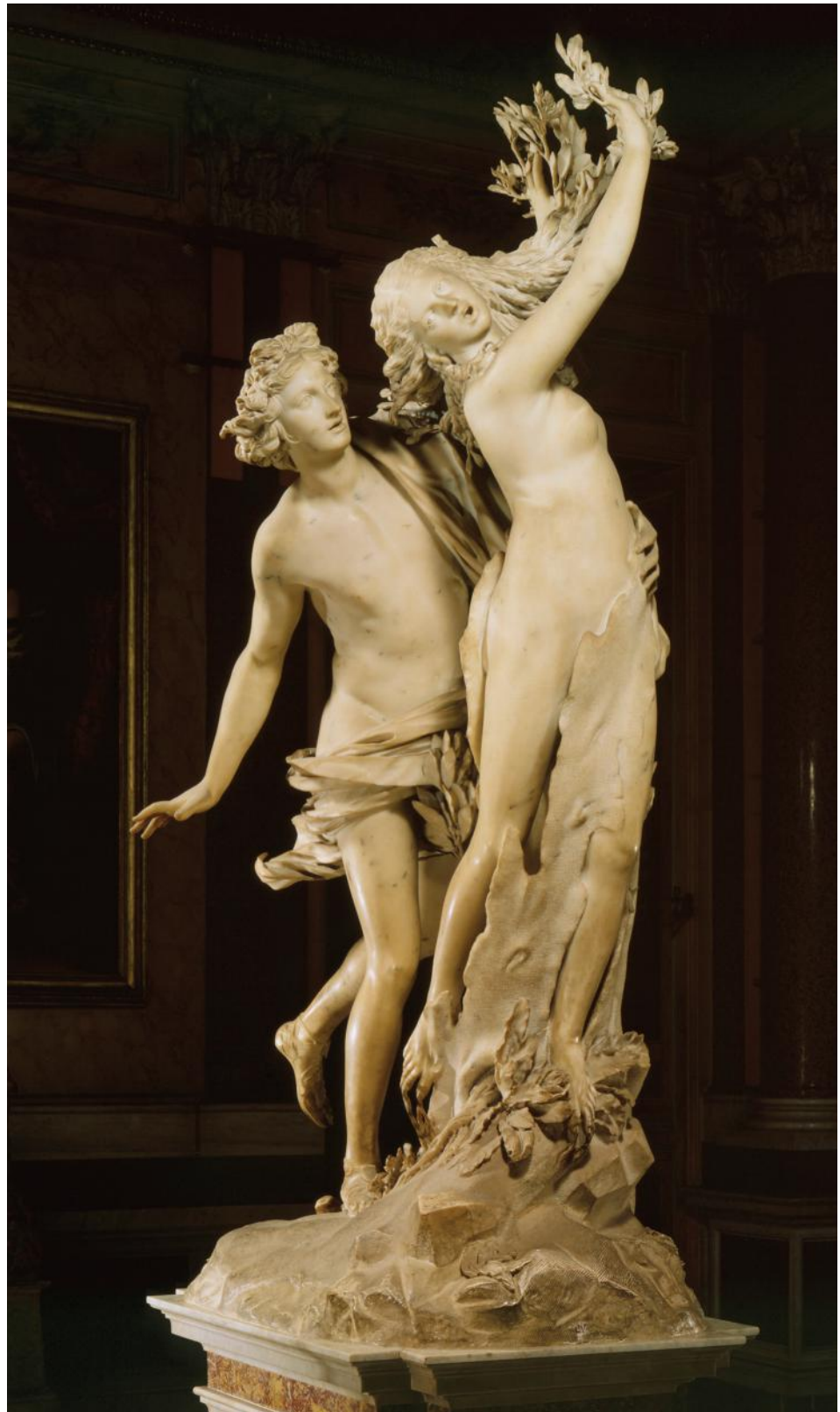


Audio

Apollo and Daphne, by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); marble, 1624; height 96 in. Bernini has chosen the moment when swift movement is stopped. The sculptor brilliantly incorporates the psychological tensions of Ovid's narrative, frozen in the moment of metamorphosis. The contrast between Apollo, adapted from the famous *Apollo Belvedere*, and the agitated emotions of Daphne serves to heighten the tragedy. On the base (not shown) are inscribed Ovid's description of the metamorphosis (*Metamorphoses* 1. 519–521) and two Latin lines by the future Pope Urban VIII: "Every lover who pursues the joys of fleeing beauty fills his hands with leaves or plucks bitter berries." (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look



He praises her fingers, hands, arms, and shoulders half-bared; those parts which are covered he thinks more beautiful. (490–502)

Swifter than the wind, Daphne runs from him and stays not to hear him call her back: “Stay, nymph! Stay, daughter of Peneus, I pray! I am not an enemy who pursues you. Stay, nymph! A lamb runs like this from the wolf, a hind from the lion, doves with fluttering wings from the eagle. Each kind runs from its enemy; love makes me pursue! Oh, take care you do not fall; let not the thorns scratch those legs that never should be marred and I be the cause of your hurt! Rough is the place where you run; run more slowly, I beg, and I will pursue more slowly. Yet consider who loves you; I am not a mountain peasant; I am not an uncouth shepherd who watches here his flocks and herds. Unheeding, you know not whom you try to escape, and therefore do you run. I am lord of Delphi, of Claros, Tenedos, and royal Patara; Jupiter is my father! I show the future, the past, the present; through me came the harmony of lyre and song! Unerring are my arrows, yet one arrow is yet more unerring and has wounded my heart, before untouched. The healing art is mine; throughout the world am I called the Bringer of Help; the power of herbs is mine to command. Ah me! for no herb can remedy love; the art which heals all cannot heal its master!” (502–524)

Even as he spoke, Daphne fled from him and ran on in fear; then too she seemed lovely—the wind laid bare her body, and her clothes fluttered as she ran and her hair streamed out behind. In flight, she was yet more beautiful. Yet the young god could not bear to have his words of love go for nothing; driven on by love, he followed at full speed. Even as a Gallic hound sees a hare in an empty field and pursues its prey as it runs for safety—the one seems just to be catching the quarry and expects each moment to have gripped it; with muzzle at full stretch, it is hot on the other’s tracks; the other hardly knows if it has been caught and avoids the snapping jaws—so the god chased the virgin: hope gave him speed; her speed came from fear. Yet the pursuer gains, helped by the wings of love; he gives her no respite; he presses hard upon her and his breath ruffles the hair upon her neck. (525–542)

Now Daphne’s strength was gone, drained by the effort of her flight, and pale she saw Peneus’ waters. “Help me, Father,” she cried, “if a river has power; change me and destroy my beauty which has proved too attractive!” Hardly had she finished her prayer when her limbs grew heavy and sluggish; thin bark enveloped her soft breasts; her hair grew into leaves, her arms into branches. Her feet, which until now had run so swiftly, held fast with clinging roots. Her face was the tree’s top; only her beauty remains. (543–552)

Even in this form Apollo loves her; placing his hand on the trunk he felt the heart beating beneath the new-formed bark. Embracing the branches, as if they were human limbs, he kisses the wood; yet the wood shrinks from his kisses. “Since you cannot be my wife,” said he, “you shall be my tree. Always you shall wreath my hair, my lyre, my quiver. You shall accompany the Roman generals when the joyous triumph hymn is sung and the long procession climbs the Capitol . . . and as my young locks have never been shorn, so may you forever be honored with green leaves!” Apollo’s speech was done: the new-made laurel nodded her assent and like a head bowed her topmost branches. (553–567)

As discussed in Chapter 1 (on p. 20), Ovid’s artistry has created a tale of passion that has inspired artists throughout the centuries.

Apollo and Hyacinthus

Apollo was also susceptible to the love of young men.²³ His devotion to Hyacinthus, a handsome Spartan youth from Amyclae, is well known from Ovid's account; the great god neglected his other duties in order to be in the company of his beloved (*Metamorphoses* 10. 174–219):

The Titan sun was almost midway between the night that had passed and the one to come—equidistant from both—when Apollo and the boy took off their garments and glistening with olive oil began to compete with the broad discus. Phoebus made the first throw. He poised the discus and hurled it so far into the air that the clouds were scattered by its course, and only after a long time, because of its own sheer weight, did it fall back again to solid earth. His throw exhibited great skill combined with great strength. Straightway Hyacinthus under the impulse of his enthusiasm, heedless of all but the game, made a dash to pick up the discus. But it bounced back, O Hyacinthus, as it hit the hard earth and struck you full in the face.²⁴ The god turned as pale as the boy himself. He took up the limp body in his attempt to revive him, frantically staying the flow of blood from the sad wound and applying herbs to sustain the life that was ebbing away. His arts were to no avail; the wound was incurable. Just as when someone in a garden breaks off violets or brittle poppies or lilies that cling to their tawny stems, and suddenly these flowers droop and fade and cannot support the tops of their heavy heads which look down to the ground, so dropped the head of the dying boy and his neck, once strength was gone, gave way to the burden of its weight and sank on his shoulder. (174–195) 10

Phoebus cried: “You slip away, cheated of your youthful prime. Your wound that I look upon accuses me. You are my grief and my guilt—my own hand is branded with your death! I am the one who is responsible. But what fault was mine? Can it be called a fault to have played a game with you, to have loved you? O that I could give you my life as you deserve or die along with you. But we are bound by fate's decree. Yet you will always be with me, your name will cling to my lips, forever remembering. You will be my theme as I pluck my lyre and sing my songs and you, a new flower, will bear markings in imitation of my grief; and there will come a time when the bravest of heroes will be linked to this same flower and his name will be read on its petals.” (196–208) 20

While Apollo spoke these words from his unerring lips, lo and behold, the blood that had poured upon the ground and stained the grass ceased to be blood and a flower arose, of a purple more brilliant than Tyrian dye; it took the shape of a lily and differed only in color, for lilies are silvery white. Apollo, though responsible for so honoring Hyacinthus, was not yet satisfied. The god himself inscribed his laments upon the petals, and the flower bears the markings of the mournful letters *AI AI*.²⁵ Sparta was proud to claim Hyacinthus as her son, and his glory endures to this day; every year a festival, the Hyacinthia, is celebrated in his honor with ceremonies ancient in their traditions. (209–219) 30

Apollo and Cyparissus

Cyparissus, from Ceos, was another youth loved by Apollo. His sad story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 10. 106–142). On the island was a very beautiful stag,

sacred to the nymphs. He had no fear of human beings and was befriended by all. But the stag was especially dear to the most handsome of Ceans, Cyparissus. He would lovingly lead the animal to fresh pastures and clear springs, weave flowers for his horns, and joyfully ride like a horseman on his back.

Unfortunately, one summer day, Cyparissus accidentally killed his beloved stag, and when he saw him dying from the cruel wound he had himself inflicted, he wanted to die too. Apollo tried in vain to comfort him. The lad only renewed his sobs and begged that the gods would grant him his ultimate wish that he might continue his mourning forever. Exhausted by grief and endless tears, his life ebbed away and he was transformed into a tree, the cypress, ever after called by his name and associated with mourning, as Apollo predicted in anguish: "You will be mourned by me, you will mourn for others and you always will be there, where others grieve."

Apollo and Coronis

Several stories emphasize Apollo's role as a god of medicine, which is taken over in large part by his son Asclepius. And this brings us to Apollo's affair with Coronis, the last we shall tell. Coronis (in Ovid's version) was a lovely maiden from Larissa in Thessaly whom Apollo loved; in fact, she was pregnant with his child. Unfortunately, the raven, Apollo's bird, saw Coronis lying with a young Thessalian and told all to the god (*Metamorphoses* 2. 600–634):

When Apollo heard this charge against Coronis, the laurel wreath slipped from his head, his expression changed, and the color drained from his cheeks. As his heart burned with swollen rage, he took up his accustomed weapons and bent his bow to string it; with his unerring arrow he pierced the breast which he had so often embraced. She gave a groan as she was struck; and when she drew the shaft from her body, red blood welled up over her white limbs. She spoke: "You could have exacted this punishment and I have paid with my life, after I had borne your child; as it is, two of us die in one." With these words her life drained away with her blood; the chill of death crept over her lifeless corpse. (600–611)

Too late, alas, the lover repented of his cruel punishment. He hated himself because he had listened to the charge against her and had been so inflamed. He hated his bow and his arrows and his hands that had so rashly shot them. He fondled her limp body and strove to thwart the Fates; but his efforts came too late, and he applied his arts of healing to no avail. When he saw that his attempts were in vain and that the pyre was being built and saw her limbs about to be burned in the last flames, then truly (for it is forbidden that the cheeks of



Amphiaraüs as Healer. Votive relief from Oropus, first quarter of the fourth century B.C. Amphiaraüs was one of the Seven against Thebes. Oropus, a city on the border between Attica and Boeotia, was the site of his famous oracle (p. 428) and a center for his healing art. At the sanctuary of Amphiaraüs (the Amphiareion), archaeologists have uncovered remains of the temple, altar, incubation hall, sacred spring, stoa, and stadium. Numerous inscriptions and votive objects, like the one shown here, have been found as well. As in the worship of Asclepius at Epidaurus, incubation was practiced. The inscription at the base of the relief records that it was dedicated by a man named Archinus to Amphiaraüs. The relief narrates the healing process. On the right, in the background, Archinus is asleep. As he sleeps, a snake, often present during incubations, appears to be biting his right shoulder. Perhaps Archinus is being visited by a divinely sent dream. In the left foreground, Amphiaraüs is personally tending to the same shoulder of Archinus. The figure on the far right may be yet another portrayal of Archinus, healed, or perhaps an attendant of the sanctuary. The relief makes the observer privy to the divine action, perhaps as envisioned by Archinus in his dream, at work behind the visible reality. (*Hellenic Ministry of Culture/Archaeological Receipts Fund*)

the gods be touched by tears) Apollo uttered groans that issued from the very depths of his heart, just as when a young cow sees the mallet poised above the right ear of her suckling calf to shatter the hollow temples with a crashing blow. He poured perfumes upon her unfeeling breast, clasped her in his embrace, and performed the proper rites so just and yet unjust. Phoebus could not bear that his own seed be reduced to the same ashes, but he snatched his son out of the flames from the womb of his mother and brought him to the cave of the centaur Chiron. The raven, who hoped for a reward for the truth of his utterances, Apollo forbade evermore to be counted among white birds. Meanwhile, the centaur was happy to have the divine infant as a foster child and delighted in such an honorable task. (612–634) 20

Asclepius, the God of Healing

Thus, like many another mythological figure, Asclepius was trained by the wise and gentle Chiron, and he learned his lessons well, particularly in the field of medicine. In the *Iliad*, Asclepius is a heroic physician, and his two sons, Machaon

Asclepius' Staff or Hermes' Caduceus as a Medical Emblem?

The staff of Asclepius, entwined by a single serpent, has been considered the true symbol for the medical profession since the second century A.D. It is derived from a walking stick, which Asclepius himself and his peripatetic followers, the Asclepiads, used in their profession as physicians. A snake (identified as the common species *Elaphe longissima*) appropriately surrounds the staff, since its shedding of its skin every year symbolizes rejuvenation, and it was thought by the ancients to be a practical healer of the sick (as we have seen). How could the single-serpent staff of the Greek god of medicine, Asclepius, clearly a symbol uniquely medical, become confused with the authoritative winged caduceus (with its two coiled serpents) of the herald and messenger Hermes, a god of multiple unmedical concerns, among them money and commerce, especially as Mercury for the Romans?

The caduceus came late as the usurper in medical symbolism. The confusion arose when the caduceus was used by publishers of books (including medical texts) as a symbol of their business. An early American dentist, Josiah Flagg, used in an advertisement a caduceus embellished with crossed toothbrushes—a splendid juxtaposition of the medical and commercial. Then, some medical associations actually adopted the caduceus officially, and in 1902 it became the symbol of the U.S. Army Medical Corps. It appears today in the logo of many associations connected with health.

Some are outraged that the caduceus as a symbol of commerce and even worse should be associated with medicine. (Hermes was also a god of dishonest eloquence and thievery.) Others suggest that Hermes' caduceus may today be as appropriate an emblem for medicine as the staff of Asclepius. After all, the important business of medicine grows ever more complex, with advertising essential for competitive marketing. So one medical doctor, Glenn W. Geelhoed, poses the dilemma: "Each of us physicians may choose what the profession should mean, and [between two serpent symbols representing very competitive ideals] adopt a symbol that is appropriate to the heritage of the professional healing art."²⁶

and Podalirius, are also skilled in medicinal practice, learned from their father. Hygeia or Hygieia (Health) and Panacea, personifications of abstract concepts, are reputed to be his children as well. As the son of Apollo, the god of medicine, Asclepius himself was transformed into a god, and his birthplace became Epidaurus, the major center of his worship. He exemplified the divine ideal of the kindly physician who restores the sick to health, a blessed savior, and a spiritual worker of miracles. As such, he became a most serious rival to Jesus of Nazareth for several centuries, and therefore Christian apologists and church fathers had good reason to fear and attack him.

After drinking the hemlock and on the point of death, Socrates spoke these last words in Plato's *Phaedo*: "Crito, we owe a cock to Asclepius. Pay it and do not neglect it." This demand by a pious man was to fulfill a vow he had forgotten or a debt of gratitude just now incurred for a good end of life, for making the soul sound and pure again, before its escape from the contaminated prison of the body.

Asclepius' chief method of healing in his sanctuaries was by **incubation** (i.e., sleeping in a holy place). After preparatory rites, patients went to sleep at night in a special building, where they were to dream, in hope of seeing an oracular vision of Asclepius, who would heal them immediately or prescribe cures (e.g., magical incantations, drinking potions, bandaging wounds with soothing remedies). Stories were told that surgical operations were magically performed on sleeping patients. After the vision of the god, snakes would move freely among patients to provide healing by licking the afflicted. Excavations reveal the importance of running spring water for curative baths and ritual purity. One should read Aristophanes' *Plutus* (*Wealth*), for the curing of Plutus' blindness by incubation—very funny, yet important evidence, just as the *Frogs* is for the celebration of the mysteries at Eleusis.

Asclepius gave his name to a guild of physicians, called Asclepiadae or Asclepiads, who considered themselves his spiritual children. Among them was **Hippocrates**, a great physician of the fifth century B.C., who founded a renowned medical school at Cos. He moved medicine out of the temples and established rational principles of therapy that raised the profession into a scientific art.²⁷

The *Homeric Hymn to Asclepius* (16) is a short and direct appeal to the mythical physician:

About the healer of sicknesses, Asclepius, son of Apollo, I begin to sing. In the Dotian plain of Argos, goddess-like Coronis, daughter of King Phlegyas, bore him, a great joy to mortals, a soother of evil pains. (1–4)
So hail to you, lord; I pray to you with my song.

Asclepius was so skilled a physician that when Hippolytus died, Artemis appealed to him to restore her devoted follower to life. Asclepius agreed and succeeded in his attempt; but he thus incurred the wrath of Zeus, who hurled him into the lower world with a thunderbolt for such a disruption of nature.

Apollo's Musical Contest with Marsyas

Apollo's skill as a musician has already been attested. Two additional stories concentrate more exclusively on the divine excellence of his art and the folly of inferiors who challenged it. The first concerns Marsyas, the satyr (as we



Closer Look

The Flaying of Marsyas, by Titian (ca. 1480–1576); 85 × 83 in. This is one of the latest of Titian's works, painted only a few years after the flaying alive by the Turks of the Venetian general Marcantonio Bragadin in 1571, after his surrender of the Cypriot city of Famagusta. Bragadin's skin was eventually returned to Venice in an urn, which was kept in the church of SS. Giovanni e Paolo. Mythology, then, and recent history meet in this painting. At the lower left Apollo, wearing the victor's laurel wreath, removes the skin of the hanging Marsyas, while a dog licks up the satyr's blood. In the upper left a follower of Apollo plays a *viola da braccio* (an instrument developed in Italy a few decades before the date of the painting), while another follower goes to work on the left leg of Marsyas. On the right an old satyr brings a bucket of water, while Midas sadly contemplates the brutal scene. Even Ovid's horrific details fall short of Titian's vision of divine cruelty. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)

previously mentioned in Chapter 8) who picked up the flute after it had been invented and then discarded by Athena. Although the goddess gave Marsyas a thrashing for taking up her instrument, he was not deterred and became so proficient that he dared to challenge Apollo himself to a contest. The condition imposed by the god was that the victor could do what he liked with the

vanquished. Of course, Apollo won, and he decided to flay Marsyas alive. Ovid describes the anguish of the satyr (*Metamorphoses* 6. 385–400):

Marsyas cried out: “Why are you stripping me of my very self? Oh no, I am sorry; the flute is not worth this torture!” As he screamed, his skin was ripped off all his body, and he was nothing but a gaping wound. Blood ran everywhere, his nerves were laid bare and exposed, and the pulse of his veins throbbed without any covering. One could make out clearly his pulsating entrails and the vital organs in his chest that lay revealed. The spirits of the countryside and the fauns who haunt the woods wept for him; and so did his brothers, the satyrs and nymphs and all who tended woolly sheep and horned cattle on those mountains—and Olympus, dear to him now, wept as well. The fertile earth grew wet as she received and drank up the tears that fell and became soaked to the veins in her depths. She formed of them a stream which she sent up into the open air. From this source a river, the clearest in all Phrygia, rushes down between its sloping banks into the sea. And it bears the name of Marsyas. 10

Apollo's Musical Contest with Pan

Apollo was involved in another musical contest, this time with the god Pan, and King Midas of Phrygia acted as one of the judges (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 11. 146–193):

Midas, in his loathing for riches,²⁸ found a retreat in the woods and the country and worshiped Pan, the god who always inhabits mountain caves. But his intelligence still remained limited, and his own foolish stupidity was going to harm him once again as it had before. There is a mountain, Tmolus, that rises high in its steep ascent with a lofty view to the sea; on one side it slopes down to Sardis, on another to the little town of Hypaepa. Here, while he was singing his songs to his gentle nymphs and playing a dainty tune on his pipes made of reeds and wax, Pan dared to belittle the music of Apollo compared to his own. (146–155)

And so he engaged in an unequal contest, with Tmolus as judge. This elderly judge took his seat on his own mountain and freed his ears of trees; only the oak remained to wreath his dark hair, and acorns hung down around his hollow temples. He turned his gaze upon the god of flocks and said: “Now the judge is ready.” Pan began to blow on his rustic pipes; and Midas, who happened to be nearby as he played, was charmed by the tune. When Pan had finished, Tmolus, the sacred god of the mountain, turned around to face Phoebus, and his forests followed the swing of his gaze. The golden head of Apollo was crowned with laurel from Parnassus, and his robe, dyed in Tyrian purple, trailed along the ground. His lyre was inlaid with precious stones and Indian ivory; he held it in his left hand with the plectrum in his right. His very stance was the stance of an artist. Then he played the strings with knowing hand; Tmolus was captivated by their sweetness and ordered Pan to concede that his pipes were inferior to the lyre. (156–171) 10

The judgment of the sacred mountain pleased everyone except Midas; he alone challenged the verdict and called it unjust. At this the god of Delos could not bear that such stupid ears retain their human shape. He made them longer, covered them with white shaggy hair, and made them flexible at their base so that they could be twitched. As for the rest of him, he remained human; in this 20



Audio

The *Alcestis* of Euripides

Apollo was enraged by the death of his son Asclepius; he did not, of course, turn against Zeus, but he killed the Cyclopes who had forged the lethal thunderbolt. Because of his crime, he was sentenced (following once again the pattern of the human social order and its codes concerning blood-guilt) to live in exile for a year under the rule of Admetus, the beneficent king of Pherae in Thessaly. Apollo felt kindly toward his master, and when he found out that Admetus had only a short time to live, he went to the Moirai and induced them, with the help of wine, to allow the king a longer life. But they imposed the condition that someone must die in his place. Admetus, however, could find no one willing to give up his or her life on his behalf (not even his aged parents) except his devoted wife, Alcestis; and he accepted her sacrifice. She is, however, rescued from the tomb in the nick of time by the good services of Heracles, who happens to be a visitor in the home of Admetus and wrestles with Death himself (*Thanatos*) for the life of Alcestis.

In his fascinating and puzzling play *Alcestis* (it is difficult to find general agreement on the interpretation of this tragicomedy), Euripides presents a touching and ironic portrait of the devoted wife and an ambiguous depiction of her distraught husband.

one respect alone he was changed, condemned to be endowed with the ears of a lumbering ass. (172–179)

Midas of course wanted to hide his vile shame, and he attempted to do so by covering his head with a purple turban. But his barber, who regularly trimmed his long hair, saw his secret. He wanted to tell about what he had seen, but he did not dare reveal Midas' disgrace. Yet it was impossible for him to keep quiet, and so he stole away and dug a hole in the ground. Into it, with the earth removed, he murmured in a low whisper that his master had ass's ears. Then he filled the hole up again, covering up the indictment he had uttered and silently stole away from the scene. But a thick cluster of trembling reeds began to grow on the spot; in a year's time, as soon as they were full grown, they betrayed the barber's secret. For, as they swayed in the gentle south wind, they echoed the words that he had buried and revealed the truth about his master's ears. (180–193)

Thus, if one listened carefully to the wind whistling in the reeds, he could hear the murmur of a whisper: "King Midas has ass's ears."²⁹

The Nature of Apollo

The facets of Apollo's character are many and complex. His complex nature sums up the many contradictions in the tragic dilemma of human existence. He is gentle and vehement, compassionate and ruthless, guilty and guiltless, healer and destroyer. The extremes of his emotion are everywhere apparent. He acts swiftly and surely against Tityus, who dared to attempt the rape of Leto, and for this crime he is punished (as we see later) in the realm of Hades. As he shot down Tityus with his arrows, Apollo acted the same way against Niobe, this time in